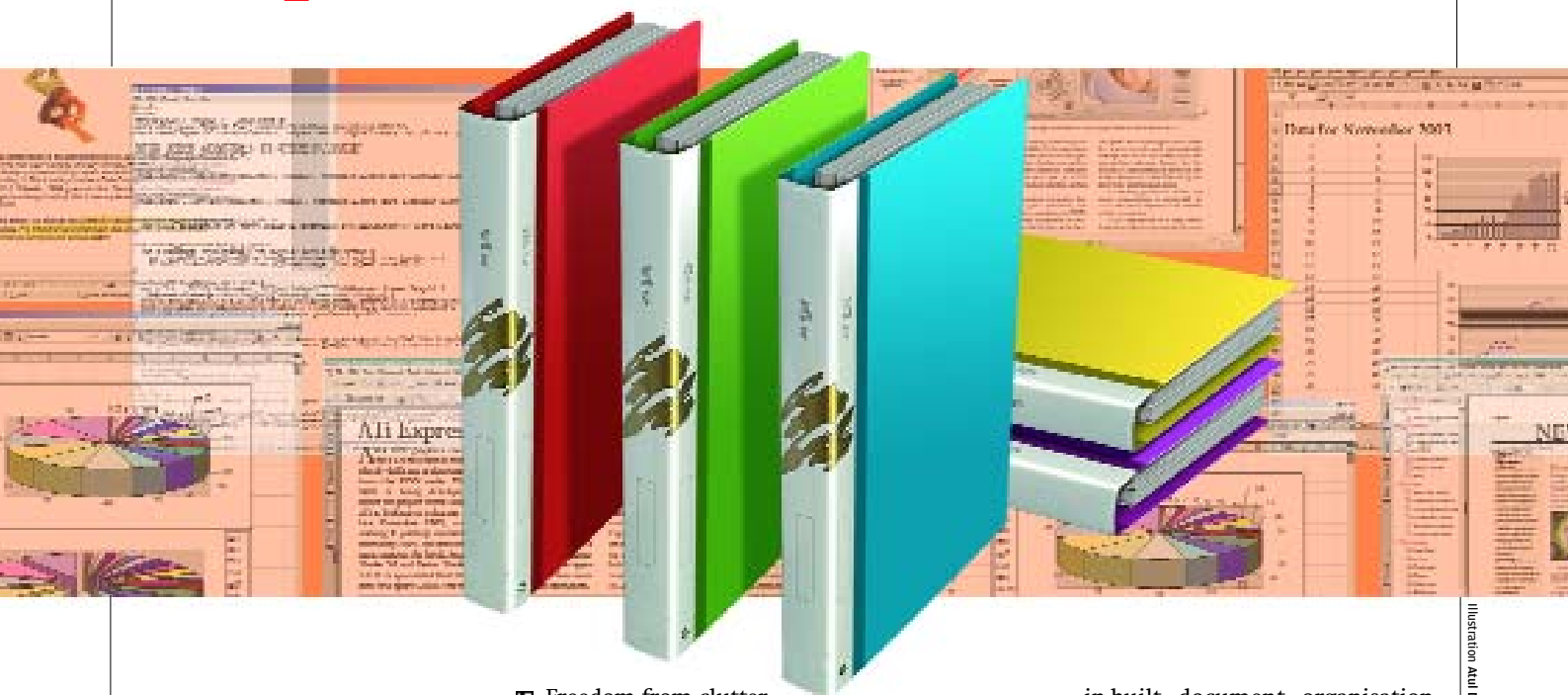


Towards the Paperless Office

Swamped by paper in your office? Digitising your documents could be your way out of the clutter



Ram Mohan Rao

It's been said all too often now—the paperless office is a dream, and it's become more of a dream since the advent of the very things that promised it. The demand for printers and printouts is only going up, with offices getting increasingly swamped in tonnes of paper. Add to that stockpiles of newspaper clippings, handwritten notes, books, the works. Hapless employees are then left swimming in a sea of paperwork. Metaphorically, at least. What can be a remedy to the paper mess? Is it really possible to have clutter-free workplaces?

First things first, though. It is not possible to have a totally paperless office, and this is something we have to accept. Besides, humans are more adept at reading paper than digital documents. Having said that, the advantages of less paper in the office are several. Besides, seamless integration of paper and digital documents is indeed possible.

Here's how you can benefit with less paper:

- Freedom from clutter
- Better, more effective organisation of information
- Cost-effectiveness, because going paperless means you cut down on physical storage space
- Better archival, and therefore, easier retrieval
- Easier communication when a piece of information is required to be sent
- Greater efficiency in the office

The questions now would be:

- Would it involve huge labour cost to digitise manually?
- How does one rely on hard disks to keep information secure?
- How does one organise compiled information?

Here's the good news: there are answers for these questions.

Hard disk reliability is not really an issue. With hard disk costs coming down by the day, taking multiple backups is a viable option. You can use backup-scheduling software like WinBackup and Second Copy to further protect your data. Also, manually digitising documents isn't as difficult as it used to be, with automatic document feeders, combined with

in-built document organisation software.

There are three fundamental operations you would need to do:

- OCR (OCR stands for Optical Character Recognition which involves scanning your pages, and storing them in text format instead of as images) your documents
- Organise and archive your data once it's done



Paper vs Paperless

Imagine a thousand sheets of paper of different kinds in your office. A rough calculation would indicate that each page is 2 KB of text with formatting. If, say, every page has a 100 KB image, these would amount to 1,00,000 KB or 100 MB of images. The text comes to approximately 2 MB. So, 100 MB of disk space would store the thousand sheets. Extrapolate this, and you would get on a 10 GB hard disk (Price: Rs 2,000), 1 lakh sheets of paper.

Normally, you would spend money on the cartridge ink, the real estate to store the documents, printer maintenance, the cost of the paper, and so on.

Digital, therefore, is the way to go. It requires only a small mindset change to go digital. Next time you need something; don't simply shoot off a printout. Instead, get a PDF, or use e-mail.